

ABSTRACT

The obesity epidemic in the United States is not evenly distributed. It is concentrated in the communities that can least afford it. Using 16 years of county-level data from the County Health Rankings (2010-2025), this study shows that poverty does not merely correlate with obesity; it predicts it, compounds it, and ensures it worsens over time. Diabetes and food insecurity follow the same gradient, suggesting a shared structural cause rather than individual failure. The evidence points to one conclusion: obesity in America is a poverty problem, and it demands a poverty solution.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Is rising adult obesity in the United States better explained by structural socioeconomic inequality than by individual behavior, and has that inequality-driven gap widened enough to constitute a geographic public health crisis?

CONCLUSION

The data are unambiguous. Across 3,000 counties and 16 years, every step down the income ladder produces worse health outcomes, and that gap is not closing. The post-2021 acceleration in the poorest counties is not a statistical anomaly; it is a warning. Treating obesity as a matter of personal choice ignores the structural forces that make healthy living harder, more expensive, and less accessible in low-income communities. Any serious policy response must move beyond individual intervention and address the economic conditions that make poor health outcomes nearly inevitable. Where you are born in America increasingly determines how healthy you will be..

References:

1. USDA Economic Research Service. Food Environment Atlas. Kaggle, 2018. <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/carrie1/food-environment-atlas>
2. University of Wisconsin Population Health Institute. County Health Rankings & Roadmaps. Robert Wood Johnson Foundation, 2010–2025. <https://www.countyhealthrankings.org>

FIG 1 · HOUSEHOLD INCOME VS. ADULT OBESITY RATE BY U.S. COUNTY

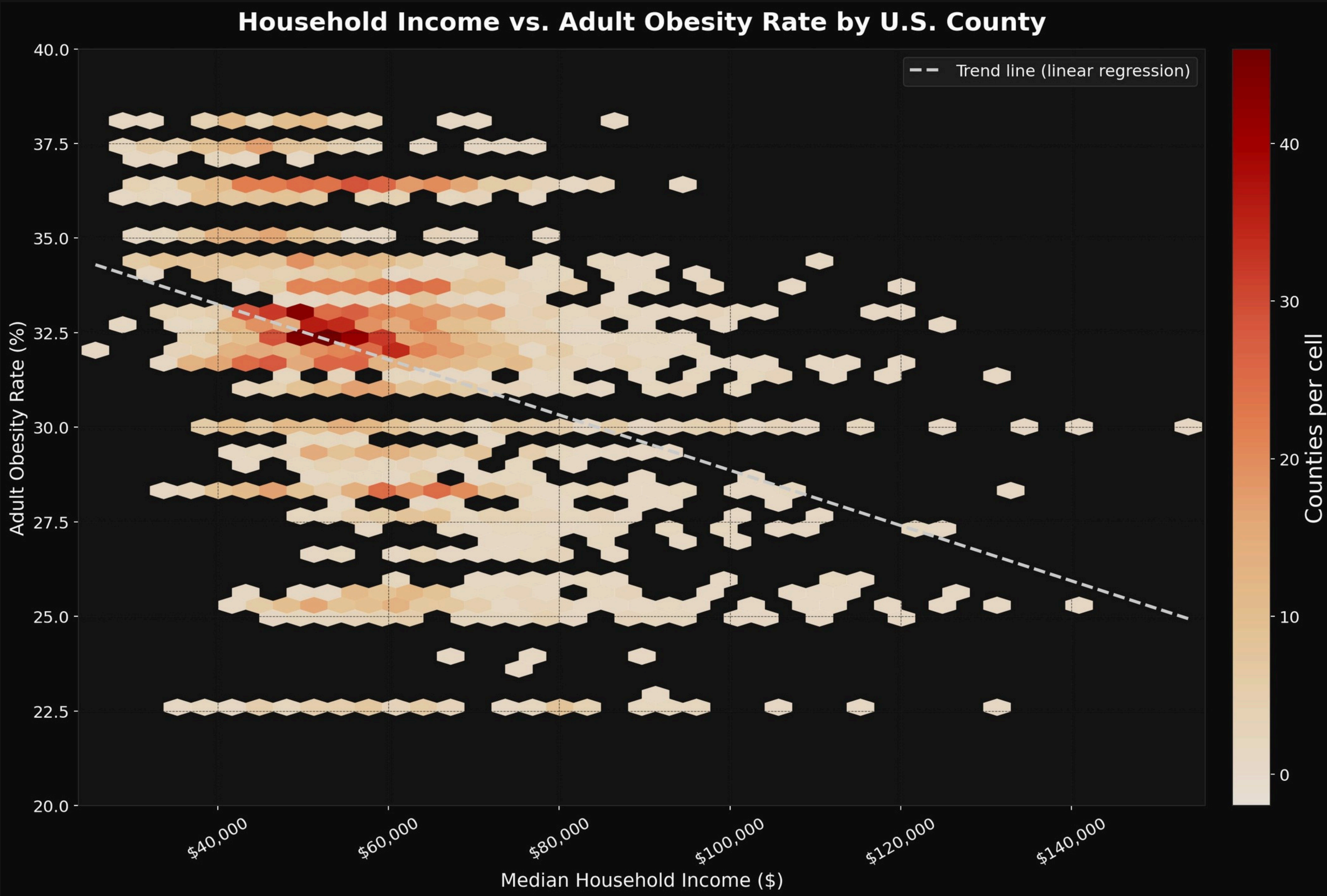


FIG 2 · OBESITY RISES FASTEST IN THE POOREST COUNTIES (2010–2025)

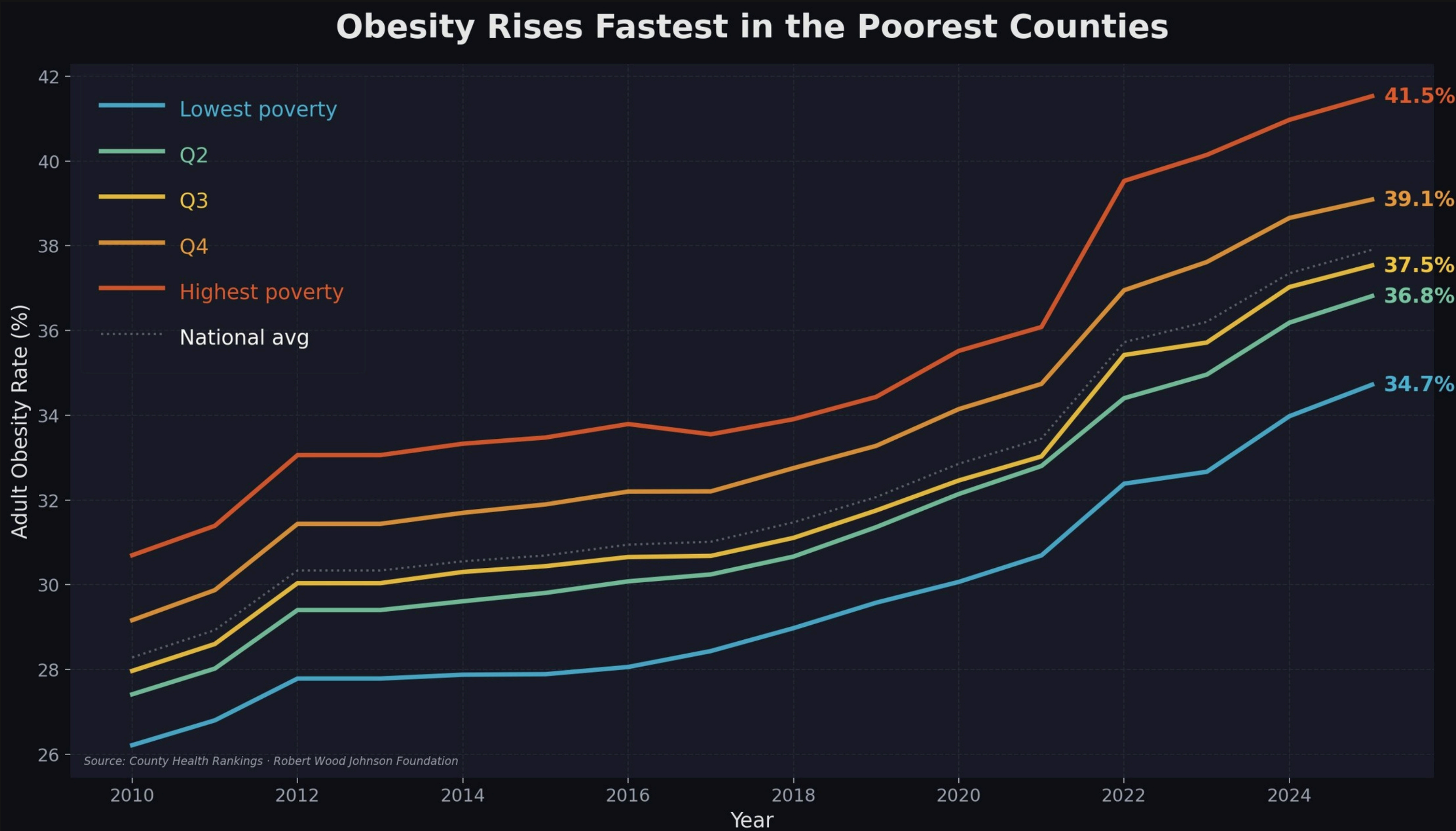


FIG 3 · WHERE OBESITY ROSE THE MOST

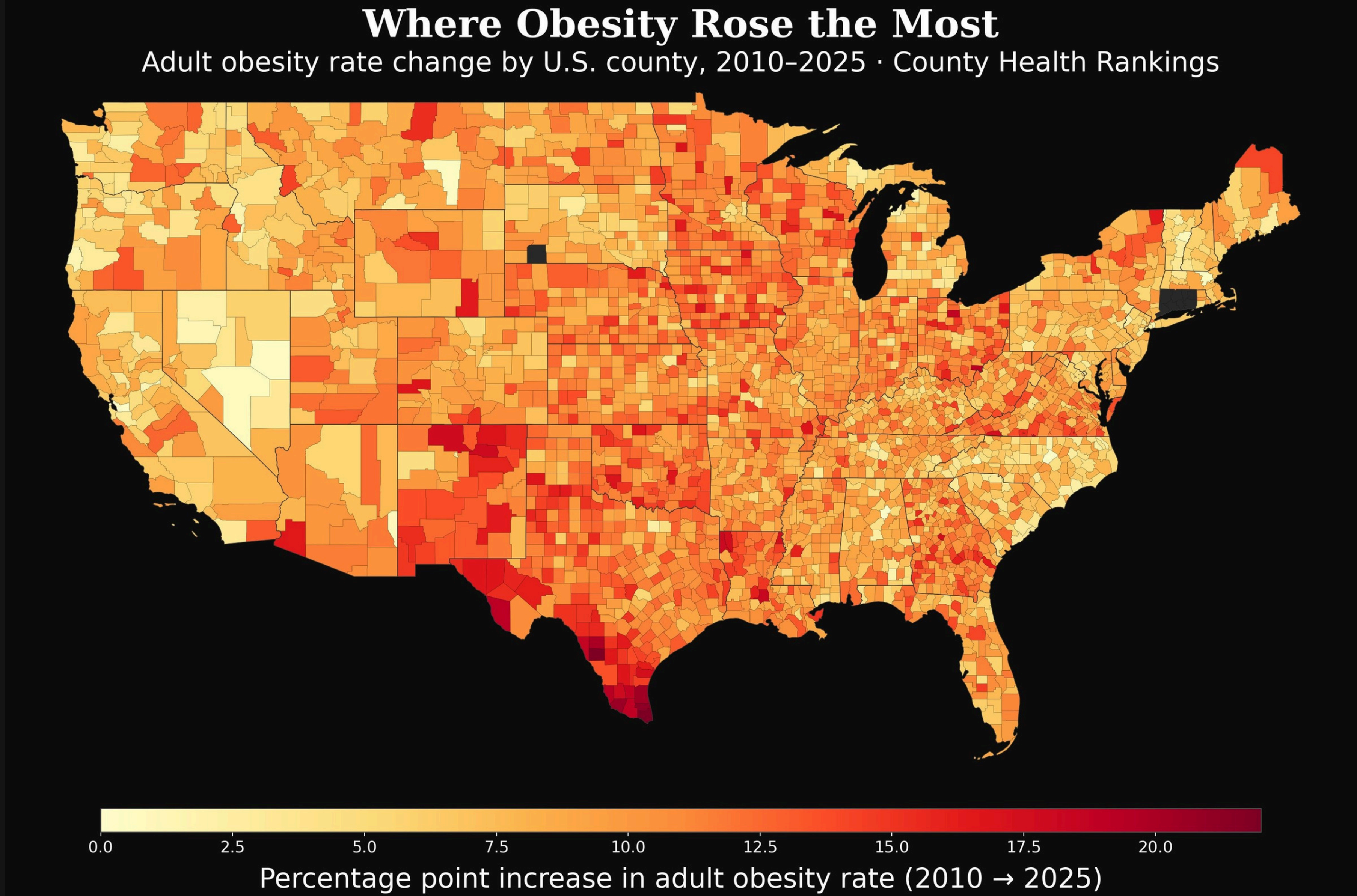


FIG 4 · EVERY STEP DOWN THE INCOME LADDER MEANS WORSE OUTCOMES

